

78 Ahab

A strong, able king who sold himself to evil, and whom God still met with warnings and mercy.

Ahab, son of Omri, was the seventh king of the northern kingdom of Israel. By worldly standards he was a success. He ruled from a splendid capital at Samaria, won battles against Syria, and made alliances by marriage with Phoenicia and Judah. But Scripture judges him by another standard. He married Jezebel, brought Baal worship into the heart of Israel, and let his wife murder an innocent man for a vineyard. Again and again God sent prophets to him. Ahab listened just enough to show he knew the truth, but never enough to change course.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Achav</i> , usually taken to mean "father's brother"
Family	Son of Omri; husband of Jezebel; father of Ahaziah, Joram, Athaliah
Reign	22 years in Samaria, c. 874–853 BC (1 Kings 16:29)
Key places	Samaria, Jezreel, Mount Carmel, Aphek, Ramoth-gilead
Key people	Jezebel, Elijah, Obadiah, Naboth, Ben-hadad, Micaiah
Death	Struck by a random arrow at Ramoth-gilead (1 Kings 22:34)
New Testament	Not named. Jezebel's name is used in Revelation 2:20

"But there was none like unto Ahab, which did sell himself to work wickedness in the sight of the LORD, whom Jezebel his wife stirred up."

1 Kings 21:25, KJV

The life of Ahab

Dates are approximate (BC). Kings does not date the middle events, so they follow the text's order.

- c. 874 BC

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King and Jezebel's husband

Ahab succeeds Omri in Samaria. He marries Jezebel of the Zidonians and builds Baal a temple and altar. *1 Kings 16:28-33*
- c. 860s BC

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The drought

Elijah announces no dew or rain but by his word. Ahab searches every nation for him. *1 Kings 17:1; 18:1-16*
- Third year of drought

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Mount Carmel

Fire falls on Elijah's sacrifice, Baal's prophets are killed, and rain returns as Ahab rides to Jezreel. *1 Kings 18:17-46*
- Syrian wars

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Two victories

Guided by a prophet, Ahab defeats Ben-hadad twice, but spares him under a treaty, and a prophet condemns it. *1 Kings 20:1-43*
- Later

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Naboth's vineyard

Jezebel has Naboth stoned, and Ahab takes his vineyard. At Elijah's word of judgment, Ahab humbles himself. *1 Kings 21:1-29*
- c. 853 BC
22nd year

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Dies at Ramoth-gilead

With Jehoshaphat as ally and ignoring Micaiah, he fights in disguise. A random arrow kills him. *1 Kings 22:1-40*

Group notes

Key activities

Outside the Bible, an inscription of the Assyrian king Shalmaneser III names "Ahab the Israelite" among the kings who fought him at Qarqar in 853 BC, with 2,000 chariots. Scripture does not mention this battle.

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- 1 Married for alliance.** He married Jezebel, a Phoenician princess, and built Baal a temple in Samaria. *1 Kings 16:31-33*

 - 2 Hunted for Elijah.** He made every nation swear they had not hidden the prophet. *1 Kings 18:10*

 - 3 Blamed the messenger.** "Art thou he that troubleth Israel?" Elijah said Ahab was the real troubler. *1 Kings 18:17-18*

 - 4 Reported to Jezebel.** After Carmel he told his wife all Elijah had done, and she vowed to kill the prophet. *1 Kings 19:1-2*

 - 5 Answered a boast.** "Let not him that girdeth on his harness boast himself as he that putteth it off." *1 Kings 20:10-11*

 - 6 Spared his enemy.** He called Ben-hadad "my brother" and let him go. A prophet said Ahab's life would go for his. *1 Kings 20:31-43*

 - 7 Sulked over a vineyard.** When Naboth would not sell, Ahab lay on his bed and would not eat. *1 Kings 21:1-4*

 - 8 Took what was not his.** Told Naboth was dead, he went at once to take the vineyard. *1 Kings 21:15-16*

 - 9 Humbled himself.** At Elijah's word he tore his clothes, fasted, and went softly. God delayed the disaster to his son's days. *1 Kings 21:27-29*

 - 10 Hated the true prophet.** He said of Micaiah, "I hate him; for he doth not prophesy good concerning me, but evil." *1 Kings 22:8*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Ahab.

Old Testament

1 Kings 16:28–22:40; 2 Chronicles 18	The main account of his reign
2 Kings 9–10	Jehu judges Ahab's house, as Elijah foretold
2 Kings 8:18, 27	"The house of Ahab" leads Judah's kings astray
2 Kings 21:3, 13	Manasseh makes a grove "as did Ahab"
Micah 6:16	"All the works of the house of Ahab"
Echo: Leviticus 25:23	Family land not sold for ever, so Naboth refused

New Testament

Luke 4:25; James 5:17	His reign's drought: "three years and six months"
Revelation 2:20	Jezebel's name used for a false teacher

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Ahab react when Naboth refused to sell his vineyard (1 Kings 21:1–4)?
2. *Understand:* God delayed judgment when Ahab humbled himself (1 Kings 21:27–29). What does that show about God?
3. *Apply:* Ahab hated Micaiah because he never said anything good about him (1 Kings 22:8). Whose honest words do you avoid, and why?
4. *Apply:* Ahab let Jezebel do the dirty work, then took the vineyard. Is there a wrong you quietly benefit from?